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A ‘Clean Fighter’

Nehru did not hesitate to recognize that Bhagat Singh became ‘a symbol’ of the honour of the nation and how a myriad songs grew about him after he avenged the death of Lala Lajpat Rai.[1] Indeed, three days after he was hanged, Pattabhi Sitaramayya, a high-ranking Congress leader and staunch Gandhi supporter, observed, ‘It is no exaggeration to say that at the moment Bhagat Singh’s name was as widely known all over India and was as popular as Gandhi’s.’[2] This was a concession he could hardly not have made, given that upon Gandhi’s arrival at the Karachi Session on 25 March 1931, he was openly insulted and faced the humiliation of having black flags waved in his face, with demonstrating youths chanting ‘Down with Gandhi’.[3] Subhas Chandra Bose noted how, overnight, ‘Bhagat Singh had become the symbol of the new awakening among the youths . . .’.[4] What distinguished him, over and above everyone else even in the violence that he had used, was as Nehru acknowledged, ‘He was a clean fighter who faced his enemy in the open field . . . He was like a spark which became a flame in a short time and spread from one end of the country to the other dispelling the prevailing darkness everywhere.’[5]

If Bhagat Singh was a spark, then his kind of spark was sorely needed in the India of the time, because as Prof. Pritam Singh has pointed out, ‘in the late 1920s and early 1930s, there were two serious ideological contenders for leadership of India’s national movement’ and that of these ‘[o]ne was Gandhism and the other was what may fairly be termed Bhagat Singhism’. Yet, ‘Gandhism and Bhagat Singhism should not be reduced to the polarity of non-violence vs violence’ because it is important to be aware that ‘Gandhism was a perspective of minimal socio-economic transformation as